PART IV · HARMONY · 8

Slash chords

C/E means one chord with a chosen bass note: play a C chord, with E as the lowest note. It is not a fraction, and not two chords.

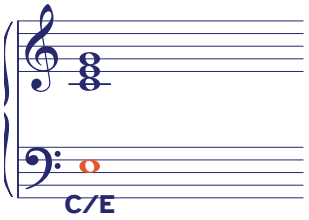
THE SECRET
Chord before the slash, bass note after it.

C/E

the chord
right hand

the bass
left hand, lowest note

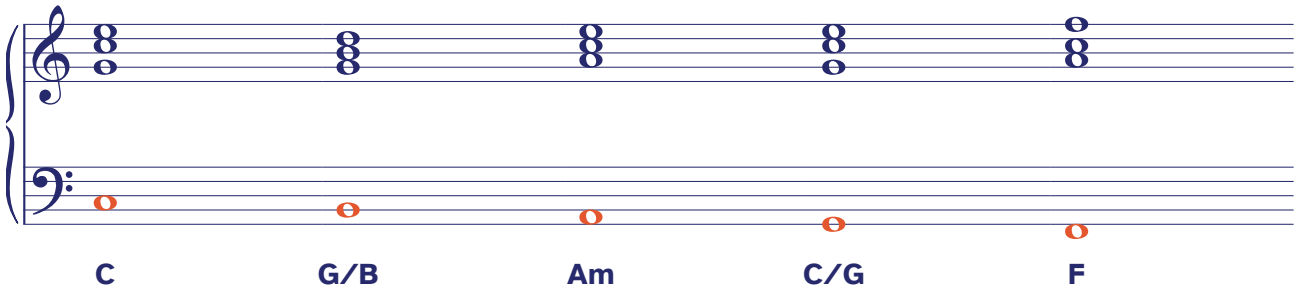
1. Before the slash: the **chord**. C means C E G, in the right hand.
2. After the slash: the **bass**. E goes in the left hand, below everything.
3. Play them together: **C/E**, “C over E”.



Four jobs for a slash chord

JOB	EXAMPLE	THE BASS NOTE IS	WHAT YOU HEAR
Inversion	C/E · C/G	a note of the chord	smoother changes (p. 95)
Walk-down	C · G/B · Am	one step down each time	a bass line that walks down
Pedal	F/C · G/C	the same note, held	chords move over a floor
Colour	F/G · D/C	not in the chord	open, modern: pop, gospel

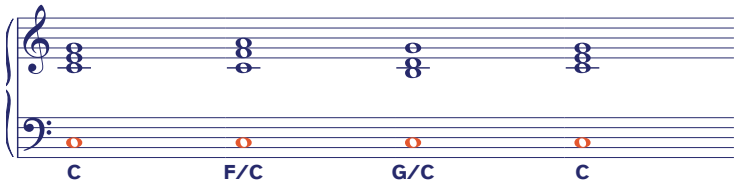
Job 2: a bass that walks down



The red bass walks straight down, C B A G F, while the right hand moves a step at most. G/B and C/G make the steps possible.

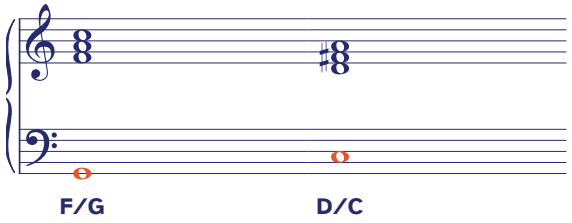
PART IV · HARMONY · 8 · CONTINUED

Job 3: a pedal, one bass under everything



The bass holds C while the chords change above it: C, F/C, G/C, C. The chords pull away from the C, then come home. (It is called a pedal after the organ's foot pedals, which hold long low notes.)

Job 4: a bass from outside the chord

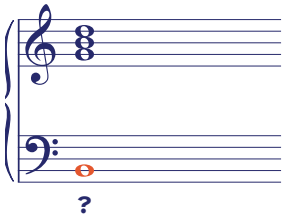


F/G: F A C over a G. G is not in the F chord, so it floats, open and unfinished, ready to land on C. Pop and gospel players love it.

D/C: D F♯ A over a C. The C is not in the D chord, so it rubs, then usually steps down to B (D/C to G/B).

EXAMPLE 1

Name it: G B D over a low B



1. **The right hand:** G B D, the G chord.
2. **The lowest note:** B, in the left hand.
3. **Chord, slash, bass:** G/B. B is in the G chord: an inversion.

It is **G/B**, "G over B": G major, 1st inversion.

GAME

Read the slash

1	2	3	4
G/B	C/G	F/A	Am/C

Before the slash: the chord. After it: the bass note. Which note goes in the left hand?

Answer: 1 B · 2 G · 3 A · 4 C.

PART IV · HARMONY · 8 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

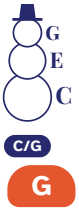


Right hand C, left hand E.

Play C E G in the right hand and a low E in the left: C/E. Now move the left hand to G: C/G. Same chord, new floor.

EXAMPLE 2

Play C/G

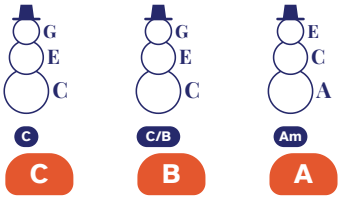


1. **Before the slash:** the chord, C E G, in the right hand.
2. **After the slash:** the bass note, a low G, in the left hand.
3. **Play them together.**

C/G: the C chord standing on a **G**.

EXAMPLE 3

Walk the bass down: C, C/B, Am



1. **Right hand** holds C E G for two chords.
2. **Left hand** walks down: C, then B.
3. **Then A**, under A C E: Am.

The bass walks **C B A**, one step at a time, while the chords hardly move.

THINK OF IT A house and the ground it stands on: the slash says what to build (the chord) and where to build it (the bass). Same house, new ground, new view.

TRAP

- × Writing it back to front: the chord comes first, the bass second. E/C would be an E chord over C.
- × Letting the right hand dip below the bass: the letter after the slash must be the lowest note you play.
- × Forgetting the chord itself: in C/E the right hand still plays the whole C chord, C E G, not just C.

SEE ALSO
Inversions p. 95 · Colour chords p. 101

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Harmony 8 · Online: Library › Chords